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from the editor-in-chief

Just six weeks ago, our cover story carried a very damn-
ing headline. It said, "Impotent India". We were report-
ing on the bomb blasts that ripped through Bangalore
and Ahmedabad on consecutive days. Our headline was
meant to reflect the passivity and inactivity of the
Government in the face of terror attacks on its citizens.

It was not provocation for the sake of sensationalism.
Our stance was driven by anger against the state's inabil-
ity to prevent repeated attacks on the man on the street.
India's continuing failure to protect its people was high-
lighted again this week when 24 people were killed in se-
rial blasts in the capital. Even though Delhi houses the
maximum number of security personnel in India, the city
has been targeted 10 times in the last nine years.

It is clear that the terrorists have changed their tactics.
From the dramatic, single, mass attack, the terrorist now
opts to set off numerous, smaller-scale serial blasts that
spread death and panic over a wider urban area.

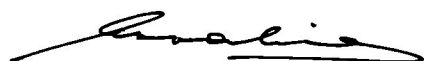
In contrast, the Government's response to terrorism is
unchanging, stagnant. It responds to old political preroga-
tives rather than the new demands being placed on it. Acts
like POTA, meant to tackle terror
through pre-emptive arrests, have
been repealed. There is still a de-
bate over the status of SIMI, a known
extremist organisation. Home
Ministry figures say that over 650
people have been killed in terrorist
attacks since 2005 but Shivraj Patil,
the man who heads the ministry,
gets to keep his job on account of
his loyalty to the Supreme Leader.

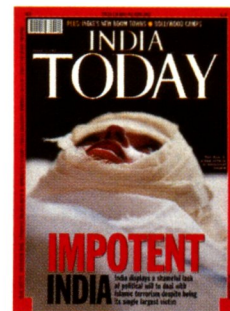
In the ancient Chinese text *The
Art of War*, general Sun Tzu ad-
vises all warriors to "know their enemy". India's enemies
have studied its rulers well. They know full well that noth-
ing will change in the Indian response to the deaths of or-
dinary people. Our government, though, has done little to
understand its adversaries and how to tackle them.

Since 2005, those who have been taking innocent lives
are not imported mercenaries. They are people amongst
us, who now call themselves the Indian Mujahideen and
who have been able to expose the country's glaring gaps
in security, vigilance and intelligence. Investigations into
the Ahmedabad blasts seem to have unearthed details of
the masterminds of India's decade of terror.

This is a pan-India network of coordinated, computer-
literate bomb-makers, led by Abdul Subhan Qureshi, now
being called India's Bin Laden. The terrorists are so con-
fident of striking at will that they send e-mailed warnings
which our security apparatus fails to respond to in time.

Our cover story this week is a look at the men who have
brought India and its citizens to their knees. The story put
together by our bureaus nationwide also examines the
politics of terror. India does not lack the means to defeat
terror; what the state lacks is the spine and the will.


(Aroon Purie)



Our August 2008 cover